America emerged stronger than ever. Take American agriculture: For decades, it had been one of the wonders of the world. For most of the postwar period, a relative handful of men and women produced enough food not only for themselves but for the growing population of America and much of the rest of the world. Along the way, though, they became too dependent on handouts and artificial price supports.

Franklin D. Roosevelt first proposed the notion of paying farmers not to plant their land as an emergency measure during the pit of the Depression. But, he said in 1933, the subsidies had to be *temporary:* It was wrong for the government to pay farmers *not* to produce and keep land fallow, FDR said.

Nevertheless, over the decades, largely because of the influence on Congress of farm states and agribusiness, the subsidies became as deeply planted in the Washington firmament as other entitlement giveaway programs. Our government paid farmers billions to grow commodities that were already in excess supply, sometimes with irrigation water subsidized at high cost by the taxpayers; then it paid them not to grow the commodities and spent millions to store the surplus that subsidies had generated. Instead of crops, farmers discovered they could harvest money from the federal pocketbook—that is, money from the pocketbooks of the rest of us. In a way, you can’t blame them. It was there to be taken.

Our farmers have always had to deal with the capriciousness of nature—floods, droughts, tornadoes. But in the late 1970s and early 1980s, they also rode a roller coaster of man-made problems: rapid inflation, high interest rates, depressed prices related to the Soviet grain embargo, then rapid disinflation. For many, it was a roller coaster ride to disaster.